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COM 2001-01 - AY2027-T1

Unit 6 Assignment

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Date: Oct 16, 2026

Ethical Dilemmas in Professional Communication: The Volkswagen Emissions Scandal

1. Ethical Challenges, Principles, and Practical Solutions

The Volkswagen emissions scandal demonstrates how unethical communication and misuse of technology can damage public trust, organizational credibility, and the environment. According to Hotten (2015), Volkswagen admitted that software installed in diesel vehicles could detect emissions testing conditions and alter engine performance to produce more favorable test results. The company promoted its diesel vehicles as environmentally friendly, while the software concealed emissions behavior under normal driving conditions. Volkswagen acknowledged that approximately 11 million vehicles worldwide were affected by the defeat device (Hotten, 2015).

The primary ethical dilemma was the conflict between achieving business objectives and fulfilling responsibilities toward customers, regulators, and society. By presenting misleading emissions results, Volkswagen compromised honesty, transparency, integrity, and accountability. Customers made purchasing decisions based on information that did not accurately represent vehicle performance. Regulators were misled, and the public was deprived of reliable information about environmental impacts. This case also raises concerns about fairness because consumers and competitors who followed applicable standards were placed at a disadvantage.

Several ethical principles were violated. First, truthfulness requires organizations to communicate accurate information rather than deliberately creating false impressions. Second, transparency requires companies to disclose relevant facts, including information that could negatively affect their reputation. Third, accountability

means accepting responsibility for decisions and their consequences instead of concealing misconduct. Finally, social responsibility requires organizations to consider the effects of their actions on communities and the environment. Mandelbaum (2020) emphasizes honesty, openness, responsibility, and respect as important foundations of ethical communication.

The consequences extend beyond financial losses. Misleading communication can result in regulatory penalties, legal disputes, reputational damage, reduced customer loyalty, and environmental harm. It can also weaken employee morale if workers believe that organizational success matters more than ethical conduct. The Volkswagen case illustrates that technology is not inherently ethical or unethical; its consequences depend on how people design, use, and communicate information about it.

A practical solution would be to establish an independent compliance and communication system. Volkswagen should use independent technical audits to verify emissions performance under laboratory and real-world driving conditions. Audit findings should be reported directly to an independent board committee rather than only to executives responsible for business performance. When misconduct is discovered, the company should promptly notify regulators and affected customers, publish verified findings, cooperate with investigations, and provide legally required remedies. A confidential whistleblowing channel should allow employees to report concerns without retaliation. These measures would help detect problems earlier, reduce further harm, and rebuild trust through demonstrable corrective action rather than public relations statements alone.

2. Ensuring Ethical Behavior in Technology and Virtual Communication

Teams can prevent similar ethical failures by integrating ethical standards into everyday digital communication and decision-making. First, organizations should develop a written code of digital conduct requiring accurate reporting, evidence-based claims, confidentiality, respect, and responsible technology use. Employees must never manipulate data, hide unfavorable results, or distribute information they know to be misleading. Important technical claims should be independently verified before they are communicated to managers, customers, or the public.

Second, organizations should establish clear accountability and oversight. Project teams should maintain accurate records of decisions, testing results, approvals, and changes to software or reports. Access controls, secure passwords, encryption, and approved communication platforms can help protect confidential information. However, security must not become an excuse to conceal misconduct from authorized regulators or other legitimate stakeholders.

Third, managers should encourage psychological safety and responsible reporting. Team members must be able to question questionable instructions, challenge inaccurate claims, and report ethical concerns without fear of punishment. Regular ethics training and independent audits can help employees recognize conflicts between business pressure and professional responsibilities.

Finally, virtual meetings should have clear agendas, inclusive participation, and written summaries of decisions and responsibilities. Huthwaite International (2021) recommends purposeful virtual communication, structured meetings, and clear messages. Teams should also verify information before sharing it, respect cultural differences, protect personal data, and obtain consent before recording meetings where appropriate.

In conclusion, ethical professional communication requires more than technical competence. It depends on honesty, transparency, accountability, and responsible leadership. By combining independent oversight, secure technology, clear communication standards, and a culture that supports speaking up, organizations can reduce ethical risks and maintain lasting trust with employees, customers, regulators, and society.

References

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